trajectories that the classical laws allow; but if we perform a huge number of identical billiard ball experiments, in 48 percent of them the ball will follow trajectory (a), in 48 percent trajectory (b), and so forth.

This conclusion is somewhat satisfying. It suggests that the laws of physics might accommodate themselves to time machines fairly nicely. There are surprises, but there seem not to be any outrageous predictions, and there is no sign of any unresolvable paradox. Indeed, the *National Enquirer,* hearing of this, could easily display a banner headline: PHYSICISTS PROVE TIME MACHINES EXIST. (That kind of outrageous distortion, of course, has been my recurrent fear.)

In the autumn of 1988, three months after the publication of our paper "Wormholes, Time Machines, and the Weak Energy Condition," Keay Davidson, a reporter for the *San Francisco Examiner,* discovered it in *Physical Review Letters* and broke the story.

It could have been worse. At least the physics community had had three months of quiet in which to absorb our ideas without the blare of sensational headlines.

But the blare was unstoppable. PHYSICISTS INVENT TIME MACHINES, read a typical headline. *California* magazine, in an article on "The Man Who Invented Time Travel," even ran a photograph of me doing physics in the nude on Palomar Mountain. I was mortified—not by the photo, but by the totally outrageous claims that I had invented time machines and time travel. *If time machines are, in fact, allowed by the laws of physics (and, as will become clear at the end of the chapter, I doubt that they are), then they are probably much farther beyond the human race's present technological capabilities than space travel was beyond the capabilities of cavemen.*

After talking with two reporters, I abandoned all efforts to stem the tide and get the story told accurately, and went into hiding. My besieged administrative assistant, Pat Lyon, had to fend off the press with a firm "Professor Thorne believes it is too early in this research effort to communicate results to the general public. When he feels he has a better understanding of whether or not time machines are forbidden by the laws of physics, he will write an article for the public, explaining."

With this chapter of this book, I am making good on that promise.